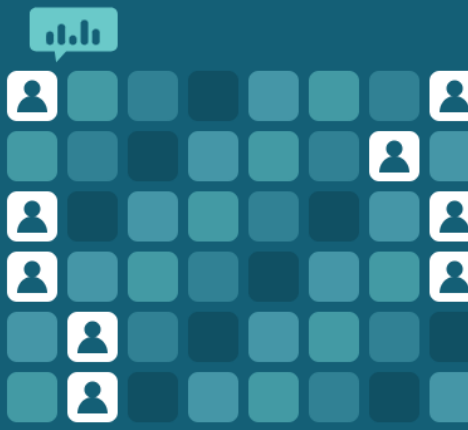
Place-based data training

Activities workbook

Module 1.2: Data governance



This training brings together practical guidance for using data in place-based work. It draws on PLACE and Seer Data's work alongside place-based initiatives across Australia.

The training covers the journey many place-based initiatives go on – from finding and accessing data to sharing it, making sense of it with community and using it to support local decisions and action.

Who is it for?

It is designed for people working in or supporting place-based initiatives. You might be new to working with data or already using and managing data as part of your everyday rhythm.

How to use this workbook

Throughout the training, you'll find opportunities to reflect on your work and consider how the ideas and tools apply in your place or initiative. This workbook brings together the activities for this module.

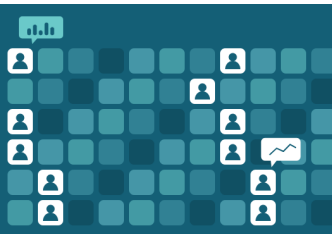
You can work through the training from beginning to end, or choose the modules most relevant to your role, experience and current work. We recommend starting with Welcome to place-based data training. You can return to other sections as you need them.

You can also connect with others doing the training to ask questions, share what you're learning and learn from their experience on PLACExCHANGE at **pxc.placeaustralia.org**.

A collaboration between

PLACE
Partnerships for Local Action & Community Empowerment

Seer
Data & Analytics



Module

1.2 Data governance

Section 1	Data types	2 activities
Section 2	Keeping data safe	2 activities
Section 3	Legal obligations & data sharing	2 activities

Try this now: name the data your initiative works with

Apply | Apply to your place 1

List two or three sets of data your initiative uses or produces. Do not record any personal or identifying information here: write what the data is about, not what is in it. Name which of the four types it is, and who holds it.

If you are not sure who holds it, write down who you will ask. This is the first part of a data governance record you will build across the module.

What the data is about	Which of the four types	Who holds it	If unsure, who I will ask

Try this now: assign the four responsibilities

Apply Apply to your place 2

The first three columns are filled in: the four responsibilities, who they are usually assigned to, and why each is monitored. Complete the last two columns for your own initiative. Where a responsibility sits with more than one organisation, write both.

For cultural protocols, the question is who holds and guides that responsibility, not what the protocols are: that judgement sits with community.

Responsibility	Usually assigned to	Why it is monitored	Who holds it here	If unsure, who I will ask
Data lifecycle management	Data owners, custodians and stewards	Gives oversight of how data is collected, stored, used, archived, and deleted, which helps prevent misuse, loss or breaches and keeps data accurate over time.		
Quality assurance	Data stewards	Regular checks for accuracy, consistency and completeness are essential to maintain trust and produce reliable insights, and keep decisions sound and evidence-based.		
Access and sharing decisions	Data owners and custodians	Deciding who can access data, on what conditions and for what purpose, supports compliance with privacy laws and ethical agreements, and reduces the risk of unauthorised access or misuse.		
Cultural protocols	Data stewards, owners, and community representatives	Critical for respecting First Nations Data Sovereignty and cultural sensitivities. Monitoring means traditional knowledge and community data are handled with respect, consent, and in line with local governance.		

> **Did you know?** Organisations use data to help with real-world problems, from predicting bushfires to designing mental health services for young people. Good governance ensures that the data is being used for good rather than harm.

Try this now: match the protection to the data

Apply Apply to your place 1

Take the data you listed in Section 1's first activity and carry it into the table below. For each one, write what governance it needs, using the table above, and who signs off before it can be shared. If you are not sure about sign-off, write down who you will ask.

The data, from Section 1	What governance it needs	Who signs off before it is shared	If unsure, who I will ask

Try this now: check the five practices against your own work

Apply Apply to your place 2

For each practice, mark where your initiative sits: in place, partly, or not yet. Then write the next step and who you would raise it with. You are not expected to fix any of this alone. Naming a gap accurately is a useful contribution.

Practice	In place, partly, or not yet	The next step, and who I would raise it with
Access controls		
Encryption		
Audit trails		
Backup and recovery plans		
Data anonymisation		

> **Did you know?** For many Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples, data is more than information. It is part of cultural identity, knowledge systems, and sovereignty. Strong data security is part of respecting Indigenous data sovereignty and helps protect community-held knowledge from misuse, unauthorised access or inappropriate sharing.

Try this now: check four good practices against a real piece of work

Apply Apply to your place 1

Four practices help data work meet ethical, inclusive and transparent standards as well as legal ones. Pick one piece of data work you have coming up, and check it against all four.

Practice	What it asks of you	What I will do, or what is in place	If unsure, who I will ask
Engage early with communities and stakeholders	Work with communities and stakeholders from the outset to co-design how data will be collected, used, and shared. Keep consent clear, meaningful, and ongoing: people should understand what data is collected, why, who will access it, and how it benefits the community. For First Nations and culturally diverse communities, consent should align with free, prior, and informed consent and respect collective decision-making.		
Maintain transparency across the data lifecycle	Communicate how data is stored, secured, and used, particularly where several partners are involved. Communities should be able to see how their data contributes to local outcomes. Dashboards, reports, or plain-language summaries support openness.		
Embed ethical oversight and reflection	Consider the ethical implications of what you intend to do, to reduce the risk of harm to people taking part. For anything beyond low-risk projects, arrange ethical oversight through review panels or community advisory groups.		
Update internal policies regularly	As privacy laws, technologies, and community expectations change, review and update data governance and privacy policies, so staff and partners stay aware of current standards.		

Try this now: find out what already covers you

Apply Apply to your place 2

Before starting new data work, it helps to check what agreements already exist. Take one piece of data you want access to, or already use, and work through the checks below.

Check	What you are looking for	What I found, or who I will ask
What already exists	An agreement held by your backbone organisation or leadership group. Many initiatives already have data sharing agreements or MOUs in place, and using them keeps you consistent with existing governance.	
A broader partnership agreement	Agreements are sometimes signed at a high level, covering several projects across a partnership. If you work under that partnership, you may already have authority to access the data.	
Governance sign-off	Whether the community governance structure, such as a local data group, leadership table, or advisory board, has reviewed it, so it reflects local values and collective decision-making.	
If nothing covers it	Which option you need, a data sharing agreement or a memorandum of understanding, and why. Use the comparison table above.	
Where you will record it	Where the data came from, under what terms, and what it can be used for.	